captured and tortured. The Chinese released them, much later, in November 1960.

## The Forward Policy

By the end of 1960, the Indian Army Chief, Gen. Thimayya, had ensured that the army was cognizant of the Chinese threat and recognised it. In May 1961, after Gen. Thimayya retired, Chinese troops occupied a pass in Aksai Chin called Dehra Compass and established a post on the Chip Chap River. The Chinese, however, did not believe that they were intruding upon Indian territory. In response, the Indians launched a policy of creating outposts behind the Chinese troops so as to cut off their supplies and force them to return to China. This has been referred to as the Forward Policy. There were eventually 60 such outposts, including 43 that lay to the north of the McMahon Line. The initial reaction of the Chinese forces was to withdraw when the Indian outposts began to advance towards them. However, this appeared to encourage the Indian forces to accelerate their Forward Policy even further. In response, the PLA adopted a policy of ‘armed coexistence’. In response to Indian outposts encircling Chinese positions, the Chinese forces would build more outposts to counter-encircle these Indian positions. This pattern of encirclement and counter-encirclement resulted in an interlocking, chessboard-like deployment of Chinese and Indian forces. Despite the leapfrogging encirclements by both sides, no hostile firing occurred from either side, as troops from both sides were under orders to fire only in self-defence.

The Forward Policy had no impact on the Chinese and only strengthened their resolve to respond with stronger troops against the Indian outposts. On 20 October 1962, Chinese artillery fire commenced across Ladakh around Daulat Beg Oldie, the Chang-Chemo and Galwan valleys; the Spanggur gap between Pangong Lake and the Spangur Lake; and at Demchok. The Chinese were looking for greater strategic depth to build the Aksai Chin highway. On 18 November 1962, the Chinese began the battle for Chushul and its airfield. Chushul was strategically located and provided